Railway Station. En route were scars of the fighting that had taken place, roofless houses with gaping windows charred by fire. The odd burnt vehicle stood abandoned by the roadside. Amid the seeming calm and hustle-bustle of city life, it was a stark reminder not to let one's guard down. Rail services had long since been suspended and the railway station, its platforms and sidings housed the Bn HQ. The station master's office had become the CO's office-cum-residence, the waiting rooms dormitory-style accommodation for the officers and JCOs. On the other side of the tracks were sidings with large sheds that became the men's living lines. It was all very makeshift and not quite the tourist haven Trincomalee was known to be. I was given a field promotion to the rank of Major and assigned to Bravo 'B' Company, which was deployed along the Inner Harbour Road, overlooking the beach. The other Companies were spread out all over the town, including at the erstwhile residence of the Governor, which was located on a headland with a majestic view of the Bay of Bengal.

Capt Lajpat, who as a Major, had been the Company Commander before me, became my company officer and took me around, explaining the role and tasks of the Bn in general and the Company in particular. This dropping down from Major to Captain was not uncommon in those days. If a vacancy existed, the senior-most Captain was given a field promotion to Major; if someone more senior came along, that officer picked up his acting rank of Major, and the juniormost reverted to the substantive rank of Captain. This was well known to the officers but rather confusing for the men who would mutter to themselves, '*Sahibji ne zarur kuch kitta hona*' (Sir must have surely done something wrong). Capt Lajpat explained to me where all the picquets had to be placed on a daily basis, the vulnerable areas that needed to be guarded and the flashpoints

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